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The Children's Hour (1934) and Sentiment Analysis

Introduction

The Children's Hour (1934) by Lillian Hellman follows Karen and Martha, co-owners of an all-girls school, where their lives are unraveled by Mary, a misbehaved student, who fabricates a rumor about their relationship being of an inappropriate nature to her grandmother. This way, Mary gets back at the headmistresses she dislikes and gets out of school through that action. The hysteria and gossip eventually spread and surrounds the community, and eventually will sever friendships, romantic relationships, and reputations. This analysis focuses on Karen and Martha's relationship across the play's three acts through sentiment analysis.

Corpus/Dataset Description

The dataset was built from the 72-page screenplay, originally a non-highlightable PDF scan from WordPress (Hellman). Transkribus was used for OCR processing, though over 2,000 lines were manually reviewed and corrected in a .txt file. Two CSV files were created: one tracking the overall sentiment scores across the three acts, and another tracking parenthetical verbs and adverbs specific to Karen and Martha. For the general sentiment in `story_sentiment.csv`, the CSV contains each line's sentiment score,

sentence number, act, and tokenized text. A separate averages CSV calculated the mean sentiment scores across all three acts. Additional CSVs were made for Karen and Martha's individual parenthetical verbs with their associated sentiment scores, and another showing the averages of verb usage across the three acts between the two characters. Using pandas, two sentiment graphs were created to visualize emotional volatility across the play.

The general sentiment of the play and the more specific analysis of the two main characters were the two central areas of focus, as they are the heart of the narrative. Hellman wrote the play around gossip as its central theme with how it cascades into damaged reputations, crumbling relationships, and uncertainty about truth in a collective space. The underlying tensions of the unsaid through things like queer feelings, repression, volatile interpersonal dynamics all culminate into moments where the unspoken feelings and rumors breaks open. When lies unravel and truth spills out, the sentiment analysis aims to capture those moments of volatility.

Methods

Text was cleaned, standardized to lowercase, and tokenized across the different acts. Lines were then separated into two categories: overall narrative sentiment at the sentence level, and character-specific analysis of parenthetical verb descriptions related to each character. To extract lines, the method used line content, speaker, and act. The addressee was determined for Karen and Martha by identifying the next speaker in sequence, which helped isolate their direct exchanges both in terms of individual

parenthetical verbs and the dialogue they spoke to one another. Regex was used to extract parenthetical verbs and store them in their respective datasets by character.

For the sentiment analysis itself, VADER scored the full play sentence-by-sentence and dialogue line-by-line. Individual scores were stored in the CSV, with a separate file holding act-level averages. Imports used were re, nltk, and pandas in a Jupyter .ipynb file.

Discussion

With all the sentiment scores considered, Act 2 is the most negative with a sentiment score of .00228, compared to Act 3 at .02333 and Act 1 at .02361. Martha also scores more negatively than Karen across the board in her verb usage. In the main character's interactions, that trend of Act 2 being the most negative sentiment still is true: Act 2 scores -.08906, followed by Act 3 at .03771 and Act 1 at .05175.

Act 2 carries the most weight in the narrative as the rumor surfaces. Students are pulled from school by panicked parents, and Karen and Martha are blindsided by the sudden departures of their pupils, then by Mrs. Tilford revealing the gossip directly to their faces, in which they sue for defamation/liable and lose. Within Act 2 alone: Karen and Martha's shock, Mrs. Tilford's disgust, Mary's sustained lying, Joe's defense of his girlfriend and friend, and Mary subtly blackmailing classmate Rosalie into fabricating the story. A lot happens. This surprised me, because I assumed Act 3 would score the most negative score. It contains Martha's realization that she is genuinely in love with Karen, outside of the rumor that named it first, and her subsequent suicide. However, Karen's choice not to fully blame Mrs. Tilford for the damage caused softens Act 3's score. She breaks the

cycle rather than continuing it, which lends the act a degree of exhausted resolution rather than pure destruction.

Act 1 being the most positive was expected since it establishes the characters at a stable point in their lives, with Karen's upcoming marriage to Joe and the opening of the school as grounding forces for Martha and Karen.

What I found most interesting were the parenthetical verbs in Acts 2 and 3. In Act 3, Karen's verbs include *shudders, suddenly, shaken, uncertain, wearily, bitterly, tensely* and Martha, included, *slowly gets up, tensely, automatically, quickly, bitterly*. The physical language of Martha's confession without the words to say it plainly. In Act 2, Karen's verbs during the confrontation with Mrs. Tilford included *incredulously, angrily, with violence, wildly*, while Martha's include *scornfully, slowly, her lips barely moving, with great force*. Hellman uses these stage directions with Karen and Martha to carry the emotional weight that the dialogue can't express directly. That restraint wasn't just stylistic in 1934, but more of a necessity to those had to live a restrained and undertone lifestyle in a queer space (Kerry).

One technical challenge was that "Mrs. Tilford" and "Mrs. Mortar" were grouped together under "Mrs." in the speaker and addressee columns of the CSV. This didn't affect the core Karen and Martha output but is worth noting as a limitation if I wanted to do analysis on the relationship between Mrs. Mortar and Martha (aunt and niece relationship for instance).

Conclusion

With the three acts, Act 2 carries the most emotional scoring and weight as it reframes the real-life impact of a rumor's momentum rather than its impact. The gossip that spreads does its worst with active destruction through the children leaving school, the doubts of relationships between Karen and Martha. The parenthetical descriptors are significant for this analysis as it provides a space where queer tensions, repression and unspoken feelings live. The explicit nature of Martha's feelings couldn't be housed, so it is expressed through the implicit of their actions and reactions to each other – especially in Martha's confessed love for Karen (Spencer). There is the missing weight of the context of Martha's death and Karen's forgiveness for the gossip and rumors, and of Martha's death that goes beyond the positive and negative scores. The data reflects that within the time period the play was written, emotions and situations that could not be verbalized still are measurable in its own way.

Work Cited

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